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When Baboons Were Falling Out of the Trees

Naturally, just when I thought I'd gotten a pretty complete education in the various scams going around, even the ones in New York, I fell for another one. And this one was actually of some consequence, instead of a mere failing to see through some guy who was trying to hustle a watch off of me. It involved a situation where I had two seconds to make a life-and-death decision, and thanks to not having a clue about the nonsense going on around me, I made the wrong one.

It was later in that season of Nathanial's ascendancy—he had indeed decisively grabbed the alpha position from Daniel the morning that I farted away with my flat tire. Richard and I had been making good progress with darting the baboons, and data were rolling in. A research vet from Nairobi, Muchemi, had come out to hang out in camp for a few weeks in order to get some samples. A euphemism: Muchemi was interested in schistosomiasis in primates and wanted fecal samples from the baboons. We were happy to oblige, even acceded to his request for samples of our own. One excellent day, we darted four animals in a morning, a record, and rode into camp yipping like cowboys. A productive pattern emerged—we darted baboons each morning, ran the experiments smoothly, threw a Frisbee around between blood samples, helped Muchemi stuff turds into his little plastic bags. It was turning into a great season.

Then one day, the warden came to camp. One was always a little bit skittish about such things—wardens visiting usually meant your permits had been revoked, or some favor was requested, or some vacationing Saudi princes were coming soon to shoot animals nearby and nosy researchers were notified to get lost for the duration. This time it was a request. It was actually the assistant warden, as the senior warden had been on leave for a while. No doubt try-

ing to show he was a gung-ho, take-charge kind of guy, he had followed up on news of a problem and was volunteering me to solve it. He had gotten some radio calls from the manager of a tourist camp at the far corner of the other end of the reserve. The man had reported that there was some sort of disease outbreak among the baboons living near his camp. They were dying in droves, "falling out of the trees." The manager had requested permission to shoot the dying ones.

The warden had said yes, and now wanted me to figure out what the problem was with the baboons, if it was curable, if it was a danger to the tourists. All very commendable, but I had mixed feelings about it. There were lots of reasons to do it. The whole thing had an air of juvenile excitement: a man in a uniform had come and given me a mission. It sounded interesting and challenging. The timing was opportune, with Muchemi and his veterinary skills on hand. Yet I was sulky about it—Muchemi's time was limited, as was mine.

But of course we would go; the warden was requesting it, and he could shut me down anytime he felt cranky, and it was essential to get some brownie points. And we might do some good. By morning, we had pulled together our supplies, ransacking the storage tent: a cage, blowgun, darts, anesthetics. Vacutainers, needles, syringes. A centrifuge and a backup hand-operated one. A hematology microscope, slides, stains. A powerverter and extra car battery to run the equipment. Tents, sleeping bags. Loads of different kinds of antibiotics, antiseptics, painkillers. Cotton swabs, bacterial culturing kits, gloves, masks, surgical scrub suits, saws for cutting through bone, instruments for doing necropsies, vats of formaldehyde.

We drove off early. Muchemi had done research in this corner of the reserve years before, collecting carnivore shit, and waxed nostalgic for his youth. We all sang. It was a gorgeous day. We were excited, buzzed, anticipatory about tackling this problem, pleased and impressed with ourselves and our preparations. I hoped the powers that be would also be impressed, maybe decide I was useful to have around, stop hassling me about permits. We felt like some sort of veterinary SWAT team, planned strategy, vowed that if things got complicated enough, we would mobilize the whole primate center in Nairobi, have teams of veterinary pathologists parachuting out of the sky dressed in dashing orange jumpsuits. We got giddy until we decided the logical place to start was to have the manager shoot one of the dying ones so that we could carry out a careful necropsy. Jesus, we were off to go kill baboons. The anxiety that had kept me awake half of the night before returned—what would we find, how many would we have to kill before we could figure out something, what if I made a mess of it, what if it was indeed a plague? I won-

dered if, when it was all over, I would think back on this morning, remembering, It had been a beautiful day, we sang, Muchemi told us about lion turds. . . .

The manager came out to meet us in the parking lot. He was an "old white hunter," actually a young version of the genre. Now, before I go on, I should put my cards on the table about how I feel about those folks. It's certainly one of the epic images to emerge from the colonial experience in Africa—Hemingway's man, the grizzled hunter, tough but fair to the natives, intuitive about the workings of an animal's mind, capable of drinking himself to near coma till dawn in a Nairobi watering hole and then getting up glinty-eyed and sober to begin the safari. Point man for saving the cowardly client at a critical moment in the hunt, seducer of the client's wife, blah blah, that whole scene. I'm sure most of them weren't like that, but that's the persona they try to pass off, so I'm willing to hold it against them. As hunting wound down and was eventually banned in Kenya, a new piece of their mythology came to force. Old hunters don't fade away: the profound respect for their worthy animal adversaries, accrued over the endless hunt, finally leads to a tiring of the killing, a desire to preserve. Turning their vast knowledge of animals to conservation, they become wardens in their later years. Certainly, some of the great epic wardens around East Africa's independence were ex-hunters, now mostly Africanized into retirement or running of tourist camps and safari companies. I don't know. I definitely don't have any careful statistics on the subject—how many became conservationists, how many simply liked blowing away animals, what percentage really did manage to look taciturn and handsome at dawn on the savanna. I'm just clearly not crazy about the whole scene.

The old hunters cum wardens cum camp managers, in turn, seem to loathe the zoologists, as a general rule. I suspect we represent a final affront, the domestication of their Africa. They are old tough Brits who were there at the beginning, didn't have much schooling, and learned about the bush from the bush, understanding the big picture. We, in turn, are generally young Americans, already a strike against us, from impossible places like Ann Arbor or Queens. We come out there and try to turn their bush into equations about vegetation, or talk about ecosystems and niches, for god's sake. We spend only short periods there (i.e., less than the hunter's lifetime) and study tiny slivers—how one species of plant pollinates, how some disease moves through ungulates, how many acres of land is needed for a whatever to survive. We're a bunch of candy-ass PhDs who know more and more about less and less and barely know how to wipe our noses when it comes to the bush. All probably true.

Thus, my biases. On closer inspection, the manager seemed slightly less legitimate as one's old white hunter. It wasn't his being young. An old white hunter is more a state of mind than a chronological fact; there are plenty enough young ones, their incipient careers crushed by the hunting ban. He was simply too pudgy, no doubt about it—stocky, with face and neck and torso going to fat. Too smooth, unwrinkled. Didn't have the dusty leather face that the hunters always manage to make appear most severe when talking about how the whole show in the Serengeti has gone to hell ever since old Jock Murray got pushed out as warden by the Africans. He had a dangerous, aggressive small mustache, and hair that looked so utterly like a bad toupee from twenty years ago that it had to be his own. He had the obligatory khaki shorts and vest, kneesocks and omnipresent cigarettes, puffed-up British accent. I've sincerely forgotten his name, which is a shame, as it would have been one of the few here that I wouldn't have changed to protect his privacy.

The warden had promised to radio-call about our arrival and hadn't. I explained ourselves, made introductions, tried to seem official and in control, as if to spread the word that they could all finally sleep easy tonight, we had come to save their baboons. He said he was delighted we were there, and didn't look delighted at all. He was clearly uncomfortable, but hard to know why. So many possible reasons. Maybe the fact that the colonial days were so far gone that he was now confronted with a black "Doctor" Muchemi, whom he ignored throughout the day. Maybe he was irritated at our descending upon him unannounced; maybe it was the general displeasure that folks who look like me always engender in the old settlers—more barbarians in their Kenya.

We chatted awhile about the volume of tourist business, the recent rains. I asked him about the status of the baboons. Unexpectedly, I found that we were beginning to parry. He said there had been some sick ones, but he didn't know if we would find any now.

I expressed surprise—"I thought they were falling out of the trees?"

"No, no, definitely not, there's just some sick ones."

"Oh, I'm sorry, I guess the warden somehow gave me the wrong impression. Maybe we could go try to find the baboons now, have a look at them?"

"I would expect you'd have some difficulty, they're frequently hard to find, sometimes go days without seeing them."

"But the warden said they were the troop that lived in the camp's garbage dump."

"Well, yes, that's true. I suppose we could look there."

I decided I had probably offended him somehow. Maybe he was irritated at us carpetbaggers turning up when he had the show under control, or he

thought I seemed too young and long-haired and unpresentable to possibly be competent. Idiotically, I decided that I would have to mollify him somehow, win his respect.

I explained our plan. We would find the baboons, have a good look at them, try to get a sense of the numbers, age, and sex distribution of the sick ones. Then, if there were any in bad shape, he should shoot some, and we would begin necropsying them, try to figure out what was happening.

He called for his gun bearer and gun, and explained to me his rationale for using that particular rifle. I didn't understand anything he said about the gun, and didn't listen to the reasons why that was the ideal one for shooting a baboon. Not surprisingly, I'm not big on guns. Once, years before, Laurence of the Hyenas and I had convinced ourselves we needed a double-barreled shotgun if we were going to walk safely through the bush. He got one, and one day, the two of us Jewish bearded hippies from Berkeley and Brooklyn went out for target practice. We drove way out to nowhere, put chewing gum in our ears to block the noise, set up buffalo skulls and tin cans as targets. Laurence at least knew how to load it, deal with a safety, that sort of thing, showed me how, yelled when I let the gun point at my foot. The whole thing, even just touching the gun, felt sullying, forbidden and furtive and unkosher. We shot for a while. Somehow, I hit the tin can when Laurence tossed it in the air. I affected a manly indifference to his praise for having done so but gave myself away by jabbering about it too much on the way home. Having gotten that out of our systems, we put the gun away forever and just made sure we were careful when we were walking in the bush. So now I nodded in a firm knowing way, not listening as the manager explained his choice.

We walked through the back end of camp, he and the gun bearer, we with some of our supplies. Past the kitchen, storage huts, staff quarters, through a foot trail in the high grass toward a thick grove of trees. Naturally, hidden in there away from the tourists would be the garbage dump. Every lodge and camp in the reserve had one—even though there was certainly not the consciousness among any of the outfits to try to get rid of the garbage properly. Safari companies that would set up temporary camps would just dump the garbage in the river. The permanent lodges dug big open pits to dump their crap, leaving it for the baboons and hyenas and vultures to fight over. Every lodge and tourist camp thus had a resident troop of baboons living on the garbage. The animals would no longer go out to forage, but would sleep in the trees above the dump, snoozing late and waiting for the daily garbage drop. I had even studied the metabolic changes that the baboons living at another lodge had gone through as they became garbage eaters, feasting on leftover

drumsticks, slabs of beef, rotting dollops of last night's custard pudding. Not surprisingly, cholesterol, insulin, and triglyceride levels rose, other aspects of metabolism went to hell in the same way that ours does when we eat the stuff. The other problem with garbage dumps is that baboons are not smart enough to know that custard pudding and drumsticks are okay to eat when they're thrown in a dump, but not okay on the outdoor buffet table at lunchtime—the baboons quickly become dangerous scavengers around the lodges themselves. And when you have concentrations of human garbage, you're just asking for concentrations of human diseases, just the sort of thing that wild primates have no immunity against. I had seen that before, and it seemed a logical reason for this disease outbreak in a garbage dump troop. None of this is any news to people familiar with the problems of bears and raccoons around garbage in the U.S. park system, but it certainly didn't seem to be much concern to any of the lodges in the reserve. But I will tirade about this some other time.

It was your typical lodge dump. So smelly, you felt a bit dizzy, acrid waves of stink heat coming off the garbage, roasting and moldering in the sun. Stale leftover smoky smell from intermittent burnings, soot and ash blown about with every breeze. Vultures and marabou storks picking and sorting, occasional metallic plinkings and clickings as rodents ran about the piles of tin cans. And at the far corner, sitting on the rim of the dump, grooming in the bushes, low in the trees, were the baboons.

Whenever I see a new baboon troop, visit some other researchers and see their animals, I feel something almost like irritation—I don't *know* them, I have no idea who they are. How can I appreciate them without yet knowing who is who, what great fights and grudges are going on, who are the epic personalities? It's like being a few pages into some massive novel and feeling impatient because you're not yet engrossed in it. You look at them and reflexively try to begin recognizing individuals: Okay, there's the one with the really sharp features and the torn ear; then there's that one with the limp; then there's the one who kind of looks like a young Saul, but his fur is lighter. You wonder, Is one of you about to have a life history that would change all my ideas about baboons? Who of you are relatives? What kind of dominance hierarchy do you have here? How long would it take for me to feel as much for you as for my baboons? Could I love one of you like Benjamin?

But that's not what we were here for. The baboons were pretty habituated, from all the humans around the camp. They seemed to be slowly filtering from out of the forest behind the dump, coming into the clearing surrounding it, looking about to see if there was any new garbage. They filed by pretty

close, gave us a good view. Occasionally, the manager would point out one of them, suggest a problem.

"That one, over there. He seems to be missing a lot of hair."

"Which one? *That* one? Nah, it's just the wind blowing it at a funny angle."

"What about that one, who's limping. She can barely walk."

"Looks like a broken leg. Probably from a fall."

He repeated again that the sick ones were probably all dead by now, that most of the troop hardly came around anymore, I would never see them.

More filtered through. A female followed by a big kid that she clearly didn't want to carry and who just as clearly wanted to be carried; the kid whined incessantly until the mother finally hauled off and slapped it in the face. Two subadult males who briefly tussled and mock-lunged at each other before they decided to find someone smaller and both chased a screaming juvenile into the bushes. A female in heat followed by a skittish nervous male whom she basically ignored. As each animal emerged from the bushes, all of us would swivel, stare with an intense focus, look like hyenas searching for someone with a flaw, the weak one. It was hot from the dump burning, it felt hot from the smell. After a while, you realized how tiring it can be just to look at something, to really *look*.

What must have been most of the troop had already come out. There was nothing wrong, so far as I could tell.

"Well, so far, they seem okay to me. Can you tell me again exactly how the sick ones looked?"

Unexpectedly, he blew up.

"I can't bloody well tell exactly how the sick ones looked. I'm no doctor. I don't know any of these fancy technical terms. I'm trying to run a camp here and I'm very busy. I thought I could just help you and the warden out. Look, a sick animal looks sick. But I'm no specialist with them."

I felt sorry. I understood, I *had* offended him, us descending on him, my trying to impress him, letting him know he could trust our competence with his animals, giving him the "This is Dr. M. and I'm Dr. S.," reciting our credentials. I must have sounded condescending, made him feel patronized. He must have felt bad and defensive that he hadn't made careful enough observations of the sick ones before they died. I should have had more tact, I thought. In actuality, I should have stopped and been cynical for just a second. Instead, I made another mistake. I tried to walk him carefully through a description, to help him out.

"Okay, did any of the sick ones look thin, were they losing weight?"

"Definitely, definitely. Some of them were skin and bones."

"Were they losing patches of fur, the rest of it looking ratty?"

"Yes, that's why I pointed out the other one, when his coat looked bad."

"Good. Did the sick ones cough?"

He elaborated. "Not all the time, but when they did, it would be for long periods, these really deep coughs, from the bottom of their lungs. You definitely got the impression something was wrong with their lungs."

Oh, why didn't I use my brains with the slightest edge of suspiciousness? Why didn't I ask, "Now, did any of them get this bright purple mange on their fur only on the left side and get these muscle spasms that would make them look like they were dancing the Charleston?" and then watch him agree? Instead, I kept feeding him symptoms.

I felt frustrated. I had tuberculosis on my mind, but it looked like the whole first wave of sick ones had already died. That seemed surprising, it doesn't usually come in clear waves of illness like that, but who knows. Without an active case to necropsy, it would be hard to confirm my suspicion, to figure out what kind of TB, what the source could be, what the best treatment was. We'd have to wait for the next outbreak, or start methodically darting and testing everyone, which would take weeks of work. If only we'd gotten here in time to get an active case, at least we could have gotten a start on this.

It was Richard who spotted him first. Another group of baboons was emerging, probably the last part of the troop. Richard gave a low sibilant sound to get our attention, then pointed silently to one hidden in the rear. Richard bent forward and arched his back, in imitation of the baboon. It was a male, a young adult. He was thin, thin coat of fur, but even. He had a high, delicate step, maybe a hint of a head shake as he walked. The main thing was that his back was arched upward. Not a whole lot, just a slight upward arch that looked intentional, that made the male look uncomfortable when he walked. It wasn't much, but it was atypical. It seemed to be an early sign of TB in a quadrapedal primate—as far as I understand it, I think that once the lungs begin to poop out and fail to exchange oxygen, a baboon begins to try to arch its back and expand its chest cavity, to try to get more air in.

He looked basically okay, a little on the skinny side but not abnormally so. But there was definitely the slight back arch.

He came forward and sat near us, shifting around to look at us, at the garbage dump, at the others, giving us a full view of him. We were alert, excited.

"That's what they look like." The manager.

"Is that how it is at the beginning of the illness?"

"Yes." We were whispering, I realized.

I asked Richard what he thought.

"His back is up, definitely."

"But not much, just a little bit."

"He is thin, but not so thin."

We all watched. I wasn't sure. The back *was* arched, and he was thin. But maybe he was just lanky, is that a crime? He didn't look feverish or out of it, but, then, I didn't know him, didn't know how he normally acted.

Suddenly, the manager said, "Well, should we check this one out?"

He had gone into a crouch and had his gun ready.

"Lemme look at him a bit more."

I went on looking, trying to remember exactly what I had learned that a tubercular monkey looks like. I reviewed the symptoms the manager had given me. I looked some more at him and at the others. I looked at the trees and at the storks and brushed away some soot from the dump that had blown on my cheek. I wondered what kind of lunch they served in this lodge. I looked at him again. He was looking at us.

"Should I shoot him?"

If this was the start of tuberculosis, we would have to get some idea of what kind, what we were up against, or else it would kill all the baboons in this part of the reserve in no time. But maybe he's just lanky. It will help to do this, to let the warden know that I actually did something. Maybe we should come back in a week and see if it has progressed at all with this guy. But the manager is going to be impatient, we're taking his time, and I've gotten him irritated enough already; he wants to get his part over with and get back to his camp. But maybe the guy's just lanky and has a funny posture. It's always interesting to do a dissection, anatomy is pretty cool. God, don't let it be a TB plague. But maybe he's just lanky.

I found myself beginning to wonder what name I would give the baboon if he were in my troop.

"I think he's about to move off." The manager, more than a bit of an edge to his voice, no longer a whisper.

The baboon looked the other way. And coughed once.

I said okay, shoot.

The manager crouched even more, took a breath, and fired point-blank at the baboon. It sounded like a little pop, like a toy sound. The baboon was off into the bushes like a shot, silently. All of them took off, some screaming. The manager had missed. He shouted that we should split up, follow, in case he

was injured, going down. He and I went one way, Richard and the gun bearer a second, Muchemi a third. But we knew he had missed. We followed some paths in the forest, baboons moving ahead of us. No blood on the trail, no screaming, just alarm calls from the baboons each time we approached them. They were moving off fast, clearly terrified. The manager was running, in an agitated state, starting up one path and changing to another, alternately crouching on the ground, looking for blood, craning his head upward to look at the baboons in the trees. He would gesture for me to stay back at various points, almost angrily, as he would suddenly slow into a cautious hyperalert few steps, looking every which way, even though the baboons were a quarter kilometer ahead of us by now. Then he would be off running again. I realized that my heart was pounding, that I was gasping; I probably hadn't been breathing the whole time I was watching the male.

They were gone, long into the thick part of the forest; no blood on the trail, no one screaming, no one shot. He had missed and finally admitted as much.

"Missed. Not surprising with that sort of wind." He was sweating. Well, so was I.

Eventually we regrouped. Everyone seemed frazzled, more than a little silent. During the walk back to the dump, the manager had turned cranky. He seemed very impatient with us now.

"Well, they're gone, and I don't suspect they'll be back in here for quite some time," his tone somehow implying it was our fault. "You're welcome to stay here and see what you can do, but I don't expect you'll be seeing any baboons here soon. Now, if you don't mind, I need to go look after my camp."

I said we would track a bit more in the forest, see if we could get closer to them again, see if there were any more we missed. He gave a suit-yourself shrug and left with the gun bearer.

Richard, Muchemi, and I went into the forest. We had all stopped breathing hard, it was quiet again, we were beginning to think. We were beginning to finally figure out what was going on. Richard had wanted to talk to me as soon as we had all reassembled. Once we got in the forest he told me that while he and the gun bearer were looking along their track, they had talked, and the gun bearer said that he had never seen any sick baboons. Richard tried a couple of different facial expressions, as if trying to prepare for whichever one I would have—an instant of looking sincerely confused, perplexed at our conflicting data, then a look of wry understanding at what was going on. We settled on the latter, as it was clear what was up.

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We slowly came out of the forest, carried our things back to the Jeep. The manager reappeared as we were getting in. I said that he was right, there probably wasn't much more we could get done today, we had other things to do, would love to stay and sort out the problem, but we probably had to be going. He agreed, thanked us for coming, invited us for lunch once we had the engine on and seemed certain of leaving. We declined, thanked him for everything, shook hands all around, left.

We were silent until we had cleared the bush and forest country around the camp and gotten back into the open savanna. As if we were unwilling to talk that close to his place.

Someone had to finally start talking, to say what we were all thinking. It was Richard.

"I think it was just a story he was saying about the baboons being sick. I think that man just likes to shoot baboons and wanted the warden to let him."

I agreed, and was about to pronounce the manager scum, but hesitated. At least one of those times when he shot at baboons, I was the one who told him to do it.

19

The Old White Man

Hanging out at the tourist camp, watching a group of Americans check in. Amid their questions and calling to each other and "Jambo's" to the staff, I noted an oddly metallic voice. I eventually spotted a tall, gangly older man, with a magnificent long backwoodsy beard, holding some sort of shaver-sized device in his hand. Each time he spoke, he held the device to what I spotted to be a hole in his throat. His lips moved, but a monotonic, metallic voice came out of the object. I assumed he'd had his trachea or larynx removed for some medical reason, and this was a voice amplifier. The thing seemed like a rather helpful, pleasing invention, and I was intrigued to note that, despite the mechanical flat quality of the sound produced, it was still possible to tell that the man had a rich, twangy Southern accent.

By early afternoon, I had discovered that the man was the center of feverish discussion among the staff at the camp. The consensus was that the man's entire throat was actually a machine. Maloi, who had once worked at a hotel in Nairobi and was considered worldly, led the discussion.

"That old white man has no throat, so now it is just a machine. I think he must have been in a car accident, or someone chopped at his neck with a machete, and he had no throat left, so the white doctors put a machine there.

"When he needs to speak, he takes the other machine, in his hand, and he puts it into his throat, so that the throat machine will work.

"That is why he has that beard, to hide the machines there, so that his wife will not be upset to look at him."

John, the bartender and purveyor of drinks during lunch, had important corroborating evidence.

"During lunch, he would not drink anything. I tried to sell him a drink, even a soda, and he would not drink. Not even water. You cannot get the machine wet, like a radio. It will make sparks and rust."

Everyone agreed and sympathized.

"So that old white man cannot even drink water. I wonder what he does when he becomes thirsty."

"There must be another hole, down below, where he can pour in water. That is why his beard is so long. He must do it in his room, when no one else is there." Everyone looked expectantly at Simon, the room steward; it would be his job to track down that piece of evidence.

"But he ate a lot of food, that old white man."

"It is to power the machine."

"With food?"

"Yes, food gives you energy," said Kasura, who had had a lot of schooling. "So the batteries will last longer."

Kamau, who was somewhat of a jokester and usually not listened to, suddenly made a logical extension to the discussion.

"You know, I do not think that old white man is a man at all. I think all of him is a machine."

"We are talking serious here, bwana, we are not kids to be kidded."

"No, I am serious. I think all of him was killed in an accident, and the white doctors have made him completely into a machine."

People snarfled and dismissed this absurd idea, and Kamau was about to defend it energetically, when one of the security guards ran in excitedly to say that the old white man was going up to the gas station, was walking there.

Everyone crowded out to watch from a distance. The man had a loping slow walk punctuated by a limp.

"Look at that, his legs are machines, look at the way he is walking." This was Kamau, whose theory was still being ignored.

"Why is he walking to the gas station?"

"He needs gas."

"Be serious, bwana."

"Look, he is going to the gas station store."

Simon had the answer.

"He is going to get motor oil. He has to pour it down his throat, so that the machine works properly."

"This is true, you have to oil machines," said Suleman, who was a driver and knew such things.

We watched him go into the store and, after some minutes, reemerge and limp back. When he was out of sight, Odhiambo, from the petrol station store, came running. He was excited.

"He bought motor oil, didn't he? Did you see him drink it?"

"No, no, it wasn't motor oil."

"What did he buy?"

"Well, at first I could not understand what the old white man was saying, with his voice machine, but then I could understand it. He bought two camera batteries."

Two camera batteries?

With shock, everyone turned to Kamau, as his face widened in fear.

"My god Jesus, they are for his eyes!"

"Kamau, Kamau is right, he is a machine."

"Oh my god, that old white man is a machine!"

Suddenly, John remembered a horrifying detail that confirmed the theory. Every African I'd ever seen in the bush is capable of picking up the hottest things imaginable without scorching their fingers—tea glasses, pieces of firewood, cooking pots—from years of handling hot things around the open cooking fires. But no one, no one, can tolerate very cold things—still too novel.

"I was bringing drinks for the other white people at his table, and I was putting ice into their cups, you know the way you must do it, with the ice in a spoon because you cannot hold it, and I dropped a piece on the table. And this old white man, he just picked up the ice in his hand."

"In his hands, his hands are machines."

"He is a machine."

"How did they do it?"

"That old woman with him, her husband must have died, and she must be very rich, and they made a machine to look like her husband. From the pictures."

"That's why the white women are always taking pictures. In case their husband dies. So they can make a machine to look like him. These white people can do that."

"And they put a tape cassette into his throat."

"But you can talk to him. I talked to him. It is not like a cassette, he will answer you," said Odhiambo, the skeptic.

"It is a special cassette. I have read about them. They have them in Nairobi," said Kasura.

"The ones that will add numbers for you."

"So that old white man is really a machine."

People were near to panicking; they were no longer amused. Suleman voiced it.

"You know, this is serious, I am really annoyed. I have to take those people out on a game drive this afternoon, and now they are sending a machine. It could be dangerous. I do not like this, I am really very annoyed. I think I will

talk to the manager." And he left for what turned out to be a drink to steel his courage before the game drive.

The panic spread. By late afternoon, everyone knew that the old white man was a machine. Simon reported seeing him carrying a luggage bag from the porch of his cabin over to his wife, and the weight of it was greatly overestimated—"Look how strong those machine arms are." He came into the bar, asking in his cassette recorder voice for a drink for his wife. John, schemer, dropped some ice intentionally and the old white man, in front of witnesses, picked it up. And, John swore, took pictures with his eyes. Not wishing to slow down the pace of the hysteria, I gave impromptu lectures on prosthetic limbs, glass eyes, fetal neuron transplants, and dentures.

Everyone crowded at a distance to watch Suleman, poor bastard, go off on the death drive with the machine and his wife and the other white tourists. Thereafter, there was a palpable air of tension, waiting for Suleman's return. Would he even return, or would the machine malfunction at some point and grab Suleman's face and shred it? Or would Suleman return as a machine himself? The various theories were expounded, and the staff quarters came closer to mutiny. Serving the guests dinner, it seemed, was fast going to be out of the question.

The vehicle returned. The couples exited, smiling, laughing. *Taking pictures.* Even the old white man was laughing, and the tourists disappeared to their tents. Suleman came out, looking okay. Everyone clustered around: What happened? What happened?

"That old white man."

"Yes, yes, what did he do?"

"That old white man. He gave me a hundred-shilling tip." A whopping good tip.

Everyone digested this and, at once, came to the same calming conclusion.

"Oh, this old white man is a good machine."

The panic subsided, and he was given excellent, if closely watched, service for the remainder of his stay.

20

The Elevator

Then there was the day that I discovered that no one knew about the knee reflex. I was sitting around with Richard at the staff quarters at the tourist lodge. He had made a joke about something, I tapped him on the knee while laughing. His leg flew out from the reflex, and he immediately asked, How did you make my leg do that? I demonstrated, he was mystified, and soon a crowd of neighbors had formed. No one had ever noticed it before. Someone got a bunch of old soda bottles from the staff canteen, and soon everyone was sitting around, slamming below their kneecaps with the bottles. "Look at this, my leg flies, I cannot stop it."

Everyone was happy and sore. I suddenly had this guess about something else that was going to be novel—eye floaters. "Have you ever looked at the sky, and seen something moving inside your eye, a little something that you can see through, just floating down?" A number of the guys gasped—it seems that they had seen floaters in their eyes and had never had the nerve to mention it. Richard grasped my arm. "My god, I have seen it, I thought there was a microscope in my eye." Clearly, he was spending too much time around me. Someone else said he always thought that his floaters meant he was chosen by Jesus for a special task. I returned him to more mundane realism by explaining how floaters are sloughed-off cell crud on the surface of the eye.

More things everyone had noticed but never had the nerve to mention to anyone. Déjà vu. "One time, I was walking by these bushes, and it was the first time, I know it, but somehow, in my head, I had already seen that bush," said one Masai, who was indeed likely to remember every bush he'd ever seen before. I hit them with the one about how when you are almost asleep, you suddenly feel like you are falling ("My god, I thought that meant I was dying," said one guy), and then you wake up before your body does.

We were all having a fabulous time—one of those days where you realize how lucky you are, getting to hang out with people from a completely differ-

ent corner of the planet. But nothing held a candle to the time I thought I was taking Richard on his first elevator ride.

It was during Nat's reign, just before he decided he had better things to do with his life than be an alpha male. We had just finished darting in our park, were on our way to freelance dart in another one, stopped in Nairobi in between for resupplying. Richard's first trip to the big city. What a blast. I dragged him from one end to the other, taught him about traffic lights. I tortured him with lectures about urban sociology, showed him his first supermarket, his first cinema, his first rush hour. He was horrified by the cars—"I think there can be so many cars here because there are no buffalo." This seemed sensible enough. A Kikuyu (the city slicker tribe in Kenya) mistook Richard for a Kikuyu and addressed him in that tribal language, and Richard glowed in his implied cosmopolitan status. Even more pleasing was Richard's first bookstore. He couldn't believe it. For reasons unknown, Richard had festered with a passion for books unmatched by almost any Kenyan I'd met, irrespective of schooling. He'd sit and plow through them with his rough English (merely his fourth language), make some headway, and get great enjoyment, although he did toss up his hands after insisting that I pass on my copy of *The Brothers Karamazov* to him ("So, Richard, how's that book going, what is it about?" "Well, it is very confusing. There are these brothers, and they are always talking, and the old man is not a good one, but then they are always talking even more, except when the women are coming in and crying. I think they are white people, but maybe not from America." After that, he gave up on it). But an entire bookstore. I gave him some money, told him to run amok, get whatever he wanted, and my heart swelled with vicarious joy.

Later, it was his first ice cream. He had spotted them first, the people with the funny pipes that they smoked with their tongues—ice cream cones. He held on to my arm in ecstasy at his first taste. Then, Kenya's first escalator, in a spanking new downtown building. It had become a local attraction, the thing for the young Nairobi swells to do, to hang out and ride the escalator, maybe take your date to it. It came with a large poster board of instructions, caveats, and disclaimers—face forward, one direction only, no goats, not responsible for pregnant women. We waited our turn, leapt on, clutching for dear life, survived.

Late afternoon, the surprise. I had decided to pull out all the stops, finagle the accounting on the grant, and splurge on one of the big downtown hotels. We checked in, got Richard his room. We were on the fifth floor. I prepared Richard for the elevator. I described how his stomach was going to feel. And then, unable to resist, I drew exploding diagrams of the various floors of the

building with the elevator shaft going up the middle, showed myself to be the son of an architect that I am.

We were ready, headed up. Richard initially noted the Muzak and the lit numbers, but then the stomach lurch began and the Montovani Orchestra version of "Love to Love You Baby" was forgotten. He clutched at me, looked green, seemed close to barfing. Fifth floor, led him out, hyperventilating. A minute passed, he gleamed at me sideways—"Gooood." Again. We rode up and down repeatedly. He warned me not to discuss the elevator with him if anyone else got on—"They will think I am a Bushman." He discovered that you cannot get to Floor 5 by pressing the buttons 2 and 3. I sent him on his first ride by himself and worried like an anxious parent.

I led him exhausted and happy to his room, prepared his first hot bath for him, and left him rolling happily in the tub, singing in his native Kipsigi.

I checked up on him an hour later. He was staring out the window, watching the traffic, shouting advice and directions to the drivers five stories below—"Watch out! Slower! Mind that lorry!" Like gnu, he said, pointing to the cars. It's because there are no buffalo here in Nairobi, I said. When I first brought him into the room and showed him the view, he swayed in vertiginous horror. Now he was leaning out a bit, although his right arm had a solid grip on the wall.

So, Richard, what has been the most interesting thing today? I asked. Maybe the bookstore, and how they cone that ice cream food. Not the elevator? I was surprised. No, not the elevator. Something was up, Richard looked furtive. Can I tell you a secret? he asked. You bet. He confessed: I have been on an elevator before, but I did not know it.

Earlier in the year, Richard had ventured to Nairobi for what was in fact the first time on a mission worthy of Kafka; he was going to change the name of his child. Richard, being modern, had insisted that his wife, in labor, hobble the miles down from their mountain village to go to the obscure bush hospital in their district, rather than just have the baby at home. By the time Richard had rushed there from the game park, some ninety miles away, the child had been born. All along, he (and perhaps even his wife—this is not clear) had decided on the name Jesse, for J. Jackson. When he arrived at the hospital, Richard discovered that the doctor, too impatient to wait for Richard's arrival to fill out the certificate (and, apparently, uninterested in whether the mother had any opinion about a name for the child), had chosen the name Hillary (although it now occurred to me that perhaps that doctor had consulted Richard's wife and this was actually the name she wanted). The certificate was already filed, the child's name was now Hillary, and the doctor threatened Richard with the police

when he was churlish enough to express meek displeasure. So Richard was on the implausible mission of sojourning to the capital and its labyrinth of bureaucracy and incompetence to try to correct the name (unsuccessfully, naturally; Hillary thrives now with that appellation, and it occurs to no one, it seems, to simply defy the government and call the child Jesse anyway).

The manager of the tourist lodge where Richard lived heard about the planned expedition. He had always been fond of Richard and could afford a kind, generous gesture to someone of Richard's status in his camp (as opposed to someone who was an employee and would thus appear to be receiving favored treatment). He arranged for Richard to be able to stay at the hotel in Nairobi that was also owned by the family that owned the tourist camp.

Richard reached Nairobi, followed the manager's directions to the hotel. The man was sensitive and urbane enough to know that Richard would need help there but would be embarrassed by that need. The manager of the Nairobi hotel was awaiting Richard, greeted him, and tactfully explained that the entire room was his to use for the night, including the bathroom, explained the best news, that dinner and breakfast would come free to Richard as part of his staying there.

"Then, he took me into a small room with no windows. At first, I thought this would be the room I would be staying in, but it was something else. The door was closed, and suddenly it was roaring and my stomach was hurting so much I thought I was dying from Nairobi already. But the other man did not notice. Then, the door opened, and everything had changed! completely!—somehow, they had rushed and changed everything, the people and chairs were gone, the desk of the manager was not there anymore, instead there was this long path and these many doors. I did not know what was happening then, but now I know that was one of these elevators."

He was deposited in his room. The curtain was already closed and Richard never considered touching it, so he never had a clue that he was no longer on the ground floor. He washed in the sink (assuming that the bathtub was far too huge to possibly hold water to be wasted on washing a person. A cow dip, perhaps?), luxuriated in the bed, had an excited, panicked start when answering the manager's solicitous phone call (Richard had seen pictures of phones and how they were held).

All was bliss until Richard became hungry. He searched up and down the hallway for the dining room. No luck. He figured that the tiny room he had been taken into when his stomach flew had something to do with their changing the whole floor to the dining room, but he didn't know where the little door was, or how to make it open, or how to have the area outside that

door changed into a dining room. He wandered up and down the halls, felt too ashamed to ask anyone a question, and eventually retired to his room, hungry and disappointed. By midnight, there was now the added fear of not being sure how he would get out in the morning, let alone get breakfast.

By dawn, he was up, with a plan. He had his things prepared, lounged in the hall, and spotted the first person leaving their room in a similar packed state. He followed them nonchalantly, soon found himself in the elevator. His stomach lurched, he attempted to keep his discomfort to himself, and soon the floor had been rearranged to the lobby. Relieved and with his hunger of secondary importance to his desire to escape, he bid farewell to the manager and fled.

"Aii, I wish I had known it was one of those elevators. I think that food must have been good, because this was a big fancy hotel. And they said I could eat all I wanted."

Later that evening, we went for more ice cream, in the hopes of healing the memory.

21

The Mound Behind the 7-Eleven

I am fairly hardened when it comes to the suffering of animals. Other more euphemistic terms might be used—I am pragmatic, or unsentimental, or internalizing. But I am hardened, I do not feel as much as I once did. When I was a kid, up through college, all I wanted to do was live alone in the bush with wild animals and study their behavior. Intellectually, nothing was as satisfying, as pure, as the study of their behavior in and of itself, nothing seemed as sacred as to just be with animals for their own sake, and the notion of animals being pained was intolerable. But my interests shifted, behavior for its own sake somehow began to seem insufficient. "Isn't this behavior miraculous?" became "Isn't this miraculous, how does it work?" and I became interested in behavior and the brain, and soon I was interested in the brain itself, and soon how its functioning fails. And by the end of the unstable years in the troop, my laboratory work had shifted exclusively to the study of diseases of the brain. Nine months each year I would spend in my lab, doing my experiments, and the suffering that the animals would endure there was appalling. They'd undergo strokes, or repeated epileptic seizures, or other neurodegenerative disorders. This is all to find out how a brain cell dies, and what can be done to prevent it—all to do something for the couple of million people each year who sustain brain damage from stroke or seizure or Alzheimer's disease. My father was nearly half a century older than I. Once he was an artist, an architect, a dean of a school of architecture, a passionately complex, subtle, difficult man. But he sustained one of those neurodegenerative disorders, and there were times that he could not identify family members, or tell where he was, or experience any of the pleasures of living that require an active, pulsating, inquisitive mind. And when I would sit in the laboratory, there were times where I'd think that there was nothing on earth that I would hesitate to do to learn how a neuron dies and how to bring my father back.

I tried to compensate for my work, but probably not enough. I remained a vegetarian when in America. I would work hard to cut every corner I could in my research, to minimize the numbers of animals, the amount of pain. But there was still dripping, searing amounts of it for them. My first day as a student when I was taught to do brain surgery on a rat, I threw up. Now, I was reaching the stage, as a postdoc, of beginning to train students, sending them off to begin the same process. I'd be horrified when my intuitions about the next step in my research would turn out to be wrong and a hundred animals would have paid for that dead end. I'd have dreams where I was Dr. Mengele—I'd wear a fresh new lab coat, and welcome the animals to their "hotel," the euphemistic nature of the word being discernible by them despite my Germanic accent. But unlike some Nazis, I was not just following orders, I was often giving them and was my own agent; but I was at war with the infarcts and ischemic cell changes and pan necrosis in my father's brain, and there was little I would not do to avenge his melting. And I was feeling less and less for the animals.

Thus, each year, I was having more of a need to return to the baboons. Among the dozens of other reasons to be there, it was good to be in a place where I was not cutting up the animals, where I was not killing them. It was good to be in a place where they didn't live in cages. In a perverse way, it was good to be in a place where they were more likely to kill me than the other way around. As an additional pleasure, I might even indirectly do them some good with my research—find out something about how some sort of environmental stressor disrupts their fertility, makes them more prone to an infectious disease. Small potatoes, but at least some pluses for a change.

One of the baboons died during a darting once. I will not tell who it was or how it happened—that story will wait for the final chapter. He died, and he was one of the ones I really cared about. Should one feel guilty about caring more for some baboons than others? Is one allowed to wish it had been a different animal? He died. Of all things, in my arms, while anesthetized, while in trouble. I tried to revive him. I did CPR, I shoved an endotracheal tube down his throat. I pounded his chest and infused an insane amount of epinephrine into him. And still he wouldn't breathe. He had actually made a death rattle, and each time I flung myself on his chest, he made a bit of a gargly sound again, and each time it triggered hope and shivers. Finally, I had pummeled and pushed and pounded and cursed until I was exhausted. I would have guessed that trying not to lose someone would be emotionally exhausting; I had no idea that it could be such a physical battle.

He was lying on his back when I gave up. I was sweating and hyperventilating, and I lay down on my back, with my head on his stomach, as if I were

a child again with my father. I thought that if he had ticks, they would be all over me soon, but I did not move. I thought that I should dissect him, add his skull to my collection, but I did not move. Instead, I held his stiffening hand, and I must have slept a bit. I awoke to find a group of Masai mamas from one of the other villages, on their way to collect firewood, staring in frightened fascination. They pointed at my face and pantomimed tears on my cheeks. In Swahili, I said, "He is dead," and that seemed to do nothing to decrease their wonder or fear. It did not seem to explain anything to them, and they ran off.

In my sleep, I had decided. I carried him to a spot under a favorite tree, and dug a hole for him there. I would not leave him for the hyenas. The Masai do that with their dead. And with their dying. For a while, teaching American school kids that such things happened in certain cultures, and might even make a certain sense, would guarantee that abuse would be heaped upon you by some Southern senator, branding you as a cultural relativist or a secular humanist. It does make sense for some cultures, but it is still sad and creepy. Laurence of the Hyenas discovered a dead Masai child, perhaps two years old, abandoned near the hyenas once. She was wrapped in an old cloak, and her head was resting on a drinking gourd. In case she became thirsty in the afterlife? More likely because it was feared that the gourd had become contaminated with whatever illness she had.

I would not leave him for the hyenas, and dug instead. It was punishing work that left me with great respect for grave diggers and grave robbers. I thought the labor would cleanse me, but it just exhausted me. I would stop and rest on him some more, caress his head. The Masai women returned with their firewood and stood awestruck at the sight of me digging a grave for a baboon. They began to approach closer, but I shouted and gesticulated like some madman, and they fled.

The hole was done. I cradled him and placed him in. I arranged a circle of olives and figs, his main foods, around him, and thought, This is not because I believe in an afterlife, this is to confuse any paleontologists who dig him up. Then I sang Russian folksongs from my youth and Mahler's *Kindertotenlieder,* and covered him with dirt and covered the mound with acacia thorns to deter the hyenas, and I went and slept in my tent until the next day.

So that was how my first baboon died in my hands. In the coming months, because of the problem whose story I am not yet ready to tell, I returned to that tree again and again to bury more. But that was the first time. When the coming disaster swept over me, it reminded me viscerally of what I already knew, why, despite my childhood desire to be a primatologist and live in the field, I had retreated from that and spent only a quarter of my time out

there. It was just too hard and too depressing. I had my hands quite full enough already trying not very successfully to keep individual brain cells from dying. It was too much to try just as unsuccessfully to save whole species and ecosystems. Every primatologist I know is losing that battle, whether their animals are being done in by habitat destruction or conflict with farmers or poaching or novel human disease or shit-brained government officials bent on harassment and maliciousness. The full-time primatologists I know always remind me of stories I read of Ishi, the last member of a particular Indian tribe, a person whose mother tongue was a dead language. Or they make me think of someone whose unlikely job would be to collect snowflakes, to rush into a warm room and observe the unique pattern under a microscope before it melts and is never seen again. Always a losing battle, and all very sad, and quite a bit too much for me, thank you.

So it was at the end of the unstable years, just after Nathanial had abdicated his alphaness, that I went to where the snowflakes are the rarest and nearest to melting, that I visited Fossey's gorillas and Fossey's grave.

Oh, what new can I say about Dian Fossey? She's been enshrined in the movies, featured in books; there will no doubt be posthumous Dian Fossey exercise videos. She was clearly the stuff of legend. She was a large, imposing, awkward woman who looked not one bit like Sigourney Weaver. By chance, the mother of a member of my lab went to high school with Fossey. The mother related that she was already difficult, withdrawn, marked. The lab member once brought in the yearbook. At age seventeen, Fossey had the hunted, ostracized, unhappy look of the high school weirdo destined to become either a reclusive field biologist or a serial murderer. At a relatively late age, she fell in love with the idea of Africa and of the mountain gorilla—the largest and last-discovered of any of the apes, studied in the field only once, cloaked in legend and misconception. Without any formal training, she decided to go to Africa and live with them. She encountered Louis Leakey, the famed paleontologist and sponsor of female primatologists, convinced him to send her to the Mountains of the Moon to study gorillas for a short stretch, and stayed on for decades. She immersed herself utterly in the gorillas, broke all the objective rules about not touching them, not interacting with them, and managed to observe astounding things about their behavior. In the process, she became more reclusive, more difficult, drove away possible collaborators and colleagues, isolated herself. She did little science of note beyond observing amazing things by sheer dint of her persistence, was openly contemptuous of most scientists doing fieldwork, and clearly wanted little more than to be a gorilla herself.

I met her once, as an undergrad at Harvard, in the mid-1970s. My scientific interests had not yet shifted from gorillas to baboons, and gorillas still resonated emotionally with me in an extraordinary way; during the intermittent periods of depression that plagued me, I was dreaming more about gorillas than about humans. Thus, it was not surprising that Fossey was one of the humans I most admired. On my wall, I kept a poem that Adrienne Rich had written about her. I thought I would swoon with pleasure at meeting her.

Fossey was at the university against her will. Despite her contempt for science and rejection of how most primatologists went about their work, she still knew more about gorillas than anyone, and other primatologists were interested. Her funding sources basically had to force her to act like a proper citizen of the scientific community—to finally finish her thesis, publish some of her information in scholarly journals, give a lecture or two. She was in Cambridge on one of those forced excursions, resentful and sullen. It was an evening seminar in the living room of the senior primatology professor, and it was jammed. Quickly, one had the sickened, guilty, voyeuristic sense of watching a bear forced to perform in some medieval circus. She sat with her knees drawn up to her chest and then suddenly burst out, pacing back and forth in front of the room, bent so that her hands hung near her knees. She mostly talked to herself, in a monotone, and nearly yelled at people when they asked questions. Once, she did yell. One professor had his young kid sitting on his lap, the kid making occasional four-year-old sounds, and suddenly Fossey stopped, pointed, and said, "Child, shut thy mouth or I will shut it for you." She rambled about her gorillas, showed that she was unaware of and disinterested in most of the questions that dominated the field, and was a bit incoherent.

I was mesmerized and more than a little bit horrified. Afterward, I went up to her and asked the question I had been preparing since I was ten—could I go to Rwanda as her research assistant and devote my life to the gorillas? She scowled at me and said yes, told me to write to her. She was allowed to escape shortly after that, I returned to my dorm in a transcendent euphoria and sent her that letter by midnight. Which she never answered. I later learned that this was her standard way of dealing with the acolytes and petitioners who would engulf her when forced into the public; say yes to anything, tell them to write, never answer.

Thus, my sole meeting with Fossey. Soon after that, her difficulties and difficultness began their attraction that was to finish her. In the rain forests of Rwanda, since time immemorial, were Batwa tribesmen, hunter-gatherers who lived by catching forest bucks with snares. Inevitably, a gorilla would step on a snare now and then and be trapped. Gangrene, death. The best evidence

indicates that these first deaths were accidental. Fossey freaked. She began to fight the tribesmen, destroying their snares, their source of food. And they began to fight back. Things escalated, and soon they were killing her gorillas intentionally, dumping their decapitated bodies on the paths to her cabin, high up in the volcanoes, while she, in turn, kidnapped those tribesmen's children.

Ultimately, some of those killers were poachers of the worst sort, killing gorillas to sell as souvenirs, but some were just tribesmen living as they had always done. Some of the gorilla killings were savage and intentional, but some were accidents. Undeniably, a more stable, rational person would have dealt with the situation in a less inflammatory way, but a more stable, rational one would never have been there to witness what was happening.

Fossey, in a turnaround, became extroverted. She ran around the world lecturing about the killings of her animals and demanding help. Her gorillas were about to be finished, the last of them—the mountain gorilla is one of the rarest, most endangered of beasts on earth, and her population of a few hundred was one of the last. She opened the field site to students, collaborators—so long as they would fight the gorilla killers. Before long, there was a split in the conservation community. Some said, Yes, let's pour money in there, but not to her. She is too inflammatory, too provocative, as long as she is there, there will be revenge killings. Get her out of there, and pour money into the dirt-poor Rwandan game park service to get some rangers up there, armed, to make the place a real wildlife preserve. And the other half said, Give her money, give her guns, if there are going to be any gorillas surviving, it will be because of her, who else cares? The former group prevailed. Money poured into the Digit Fund, named for her most beloved animal, whose butchered body was left for her to find. A real, functioning, protective park service was established, enough interest was generated to start gorilla-watching tourism that has continued to fund the park and the local economy. The gorillas started to do better, perhaps increasing in numbers. And Fossey was sent away. Some sort of visiting adjunct professorship was rigged up for her at Cornell, where, by most reports, she sank into depression and alcoholism.

The final chapter was set. Against everyone's pleading, she returned to Rwanda and her gorillas. She fought with the poachers and the tribesmen, fought with the rangers who led the tourists that she loathed, fought with the agricultural tribesmen whose slash-and-burning was decimating the remnants of the rain forest, fought with the government. Her health was destroyed by drinking and chain-smoking and emphysema, trying to live in humid, high-altitude conditions. She could barely walk, had to be carried up to her cabin. Where she was murdered one night. The government lamely

and unconvincingly blamed an American grad student and condemned him to death in absentia after making sure he had left the country, and everyone felt sure it was poachers or government rangers. The funeral service was held near her cabin, a week after Christmas, and was conducted by a missionary who said, "Last week the world did honor to a long-ago event that changed its history—the coming of the Lord to earth. We see at our feet here a parable of that magnificent condescension—Dian Fossey, born to a home of comfort and privilege that she left by her own choice to live among a race faced with extinction. . . . And if you think that the distance Christ had to come to take the likeness of Man is not so great as that from man to gorilla, then you don't know men. Or gorillas. Or God." And, as per her wish, she was buried in the graveyard of her slain gorillas, next to Digit.

It was six months after her murder that I visited the gorillas. I had tried to hitchhike to Rwanda years before and got nowhere. Now, I had finally passed that maturational stage when you can no longer afford the time to travel great distances by hitching, but cannot yet afford the money for something faster. I flew with two friends into Kigali, the capital, and we headed out toward the gorillas. There was a different feel from Kenya in many ways. For one thing, everyone was speaking French and was named Jean-Dominique and Boniface, which seemed oddly disconcerting to me. Another difference was the brutally dichotomized tribal tension, in contrast to the chaotic and shifting tribal alliances of Kenya. Here, nearly everyone was either of the Hutu or Tutsi tribe, and I could just smell the animosity, which was destined to explode a few years later into a genocide of the latter tribe by the former on a scale that would take the world's breath away, had anyone cared to notice it. And another key difference was a staggering population density, the highest on earth. Endless hills with endless terraces and endless farms to feed the dirt-poor country, people jammed in, every inch under cultivation, up to the very west, the very last edge of the country. There, forming the border between Zaire to the west and Rwanda and Uganda to the east, are the Ruwenzoris, the famed Mountains of the Moon, which continue here to the south as the Virungas, a ribbon of mammoth volcanoes between Zaire and Rwanda, rising up to more than 15,000 feet, rugged, jutting, one after another after another, snow on top spilling into the Congo, wild rain forest below. And because they are too steep for even the desperate farmers to try to squeeze food out of, on the saddles and slopes survive the last mountain gorillas on earth.

We had the typical hassles with the park officials, who had lost the reservations I had made more than a year before to see the gorillas, but who located

them for a price. We splurged and stayed in the only real hotel in Ruhengeri, the town at the entrance to the park. It was a ramshackle old jobbie, dripping with colonial nostalgia. Parquet floors and old prints everywhere of Notre Dame, and a five-course meal with things like asparagus au gratin. We slept fitfully, feeling the volcanoes hovering over us, and were agitatedly ready by dawn.

We hiked up with park rangers, the men who find the gorilla groups each day for the eighteen tourists allowed in to see the three groups on display. The rangers were silent men who moved with smooth, frictionless gestures. Throughout the week I spent there, I noticed this in all the rangers who spent time around the gorillas—the need to glide silently and slowly around them.

We set off through the farm fields, already angled steeply where they weren't terraced, weaving our way through huts and rows of corn and kids fairly oblivious to us. At the end, a wall of bamboo and a slight forest path through it. In, winding higher up, steep unstable slopes. Bamboo everywhere, moss-covered hagenia trees that have always looked silly to me unless they are shrouded in mist. Higher, onto a saddle of one of the volcanoes, a view of forest ahead of us, a small lake, fields of bushes. Onward, the rangers macheteing a way through fields of stinging nettles. Clouds and mist and chills and heat, somehow all simultaneously. Sweating and shivering. Sliding down a deep ravine, clambering the way back up the other side, more nettles, more bamboo. A few hours had passed and yet the rangers continued their silent, coordinated movement. One would examine some broken bamboo shoots, another would sniff the flattened grass around there. Gorillas, but from yesterday, they concluded.

Another hour. Misty rain, but somehow warmer. More nettles. Something resembling a real path and a flattened clump of grass to the left of it. Large, fibrous, shredded turds in the middle, the type you would expect from a pro football player gone vegetarian. The gorillas. Fresh, last night's nest.

Pushing ahead, tired and excited and impatient. Down another ravine, and one of the rangers hears a murmur up the other side. We stop, silent, willing to invent the sound to convince ourselves that they are close, and suddenly, we hear the unmistakable murmur, deep, throaty, slow-motion, paternal. We rush/tiptoe up the other side and, on top of the ridge, I see my first wild mountain gorillas.

It was a group of perhaps a dozen. A prime-aged male—a silverback. Some females with infants, a few lurking younger males, some adolescents. The silverback played with the kids. The mothers fed, lumbering about with the infants carried dorsal. The two young males spent most of an hour wrestling, rolling around with each other, mouthing each other in restrained bites. They'd pant as they rolled and tickled each other, get exhausted from the

excitement, and have to retreat to their separate corners to catch their breaths. Refreshed, one would pound its chest and they'd launch themselves at each other again. At one point, both ambled over to sit next to me and stare, one leaning in so close that the rangers forced me to lean back. They had a comforting, musty, damp smell to them, like opening a trunk from the mildewed corners of a cellar that contains forgotten beloved objects.

I had a flood of thoughts and feelings. At the first sight, I thought, Now my eyes will well up with tears, but I was too intent on watching for that to happen. I wondered what my social rank would be if I had wound up a mountain gorilla. I was mesmerized by their eyes; their faces seemed less emotionally expressive than those of chimps or even baboons, but their eyes, you wanted to go swimming in. I tried not to make eye contact, not only because it's bad field technique and discomforts primates, but because the act would make me want to confess to unlikely crimes. I found myself with the barely controllable urge to scream, or to gibber dangerously among them, or to rudely kiss one, so that they would stomp me to death then and there and stop my suspense. I thought, They are far less socially interactive than baboons, they're kind of boring in fact—thank god I didn't come to study them, I'd be a fourteenth-year grad student by now. And at the same time, I thought I never wanted to budge from my spot.

That night, sleeping in my tent on the mountain's slopes, I had a dream that summarized my feelings far better than I could when awake. It was a dream so tender, so ludicrously sentimental, so full of beliefs that I do not have when awake, that I still marvel at it. I dreamt that a certain brand of theology turned out to be true. I dreamt that God and angels and seraphs and devils all existed, in a very literal way, each with potential strengths and frailties much like our own. And I dreamt that the rain forests of the Mountains of the Moon were where god placed the occasional angel born with Down's syndrome.

My friends left the next day. I stayed another week, going back to the gorillas repeatedly. It was heaven, but with each day, I felt more depressed. The gorillas were wondrous, but the weight of what was gone, removed, unmentioned, unanswered, irrevocable, became heavier. I felt it in the park headquarters, where the posters on the park's history made more mention of nineteenth-century Belgian colonials than of Fossey. With the rangers, who would say, Yes, we knew Fossey, and then change the subject. With the gorillas, where you would watch a mother hold her child and nibble at bamboo, and all the while hear the farmers, their chickens, the school kids, 200 yards down the slope, where the slash-and-burning had finally stopped. On the miles and miles of empty rain forest paths aching with no more gorillas. And finally, from

atop the nearly 15,000-foot Mt. Karisimbi, the highest point in the range, where I climbed to peer down and discover that the massive, endless, magisterial, mythic Virungas were nearly gone, a tiny narrow ribbon of forest engulfed by the infinity of terraces spreading from Rwanda to Uganda. It almost seemed like a domestic conspiracy on the part of the farms—an endless world packed with farmers trying to eke out a living, a world with no room for rain forests or the moon's mountains, a conspiracy to forget them altogether. It was as if just behind a 7-Eleven store in some innocuous Iowa farm town there was a mist-shrouded 15,000-foot mound on top of which was a book listing the dates of birth and death of every person who will ever live, and no one seemed to notice that the mound was there.

It was on top of that mountain that the week finally got to me and I had a night of African paranoia. You weren't allowed to hike alone in the range. Instead, a ranger had to be hired as a guide. Hauling to the top of the highest volcano around was clearly not their idea of fun, and the most junior of the rangers was given the task. From previous days of hanging around the rangers, I had noticed him and already had a dislike for him; even the other rangers seemed to ostracize him. He was a sullen, sloe-eyed kid, with a face like a mask and a tense air of violence about him. He mostly sat off on the side of the camp and seemed to get into a lot of monosyllabic arguments when he did interact. I wasn't crazy about heading off with him, and from what little I could read of him, the feeling was mutual.

As we started hiking, my dislike for my guide began to build. I could elicit nothing more than grunts out of him, as I tried in French, Swahili, English, my twenty words of Kirwanda. I slipped and fell on a wet rock at one point, and he laughed; it had a sneering, dismissive whine to it. Once, he flung stones at grazing forest bucks, probably both to hurt them and to deprive me of the view.

My dislike simmered, and his of me seemed to be doing the same. Somehow, these mutual feelings evolved, wordlessly, into competition, a childish angry race. We began to hike faster, moving more relentlessly, until we were racing up the mountain, seeing who would first ask to rest. We pushed harder and harder, through the rain forest, montane forest, patchy woodland, open moorland where we sank to our knees in mud, to stark open rock with patches of frost, from 7,000 to 14,000 feet in a few hours. The air got thinner, I felt an edge of altitude sickness, my vision got blurry, my chest throbbed. He climbed these mountains for a living, and I had the heavier pack, but sheer anger let me keep pace with him. *"Fatigué?"* he would ask in French, and I would gasp, *"Non."* Once, he spoke his longest pronouncement: *"Je pense tu es fatigué. Tu es mzee* [Swahili for an old man]." I nearly sprinted after him, hoping to kill

him. At one triumphant point, I got ahead for a minute, and was able to whisper the same breathless *"Fatigué?"* to him, while he gasped, *"Non."*

There was not even a hint of the mythic camaraderie that enemies are said to feel for each other in a tough battle. He was a stupid, cruel kid who threw rocks at animals in Rwanda's last rain forest, and I wanted to prove something to him, although I was not sure what.

We reached our goal, a corrugated metal shelter near the rim of the crater, just as an ice storm let loose. We lay in there, gasping, as the storm closed in and pounded on the metal. And there we stayed, from midafternoon until the next morning. We ate a bit, rice and French bread, but everything tends to taste sickening at that altitude. Your eyes throb, your balls throb, your head hurts constantly, your chest aches with each breath, everything is straining. At that altitude, my resting heart rate is usually about 110, which means you wake from presumably relaxing sleep already feeling like you've been climbing stairs.

We lay on the wooden floor, as far away from each other as the small shelter would allow. I tried to play recorder, but didn't have the breath; instead, I mostly thought about gorillas. He muttered to himself and scraped his name, Bonaventre, into the metal with his machete, all the while smoking in our closed hut at 14,000 feet, even after I asked him to stop.

So the hours passed, until sometime around nightfall, as I still lay there with my eyeballs throbbing 110 times a minute, it occurred to me for the first time to become afraid. Not only was Fossey murdered just six months before on this mountain, not only was it probably not the American student who did it, not only was it probably a government person, not only probably a ranger (I had now decided), not only was it probably this kid with the very same machete he was now holding, but tonight was almost certainly my night to get it. This may now sound facetious or exaggerated or farcical or just paranoid, but I was suddenly terribly frightened. I was alone on some volcano in a Central African country where I didn't know a soul, shut in this hut in the middle of an ice storm with a ranger, and I felt sure now the rangers had killed Fossey. As I reviewed the day, the week, my every word and action now seemed to have sealed my doom, to have convinced the watching rangers that I must be killed.

I was genuinely frightened, near to panic. I desperately wanted to escape. I struggled to control my breathing, thought to cry out for help. I lay awake most of the night, with my pocketknife opened at my side, and truly thought I was going to die. The ranger, meanwhile, spent the night talking in his sleep—mutterings, and harsh muffled barks.

At dawn, I felt foolish and angry and relieved, and felt I had been lucky this time. We struggled up the ice-coated rocks and were at the summit by

7:00. He sat, looked impatient, and kicked at rocks. I looked out over Rwanda, Uganda, Zaire, and tried to imagine that it was once all rain forest full with gorillas. He clearly wanted us to head down immediately; I could have stayed there forever. He was saved from that fate, as the clouds rolled in, obscuring all view and forcing us down.

If the goal of yesterday's race was to give the other a heart attack, today's was to get the other to break his leg. We ran down, silently; leaping down rocks, twisting and changing directions on the wet steep path. He presumably was in a rush to finish this job and return to sitting sullenly at the ranger station. I was in a rush to be away from this mountain and my sleepless night there, to be rid of this murderer.

We ran down the ice-covered rocks. We ran through the near frozen mud fields of the moorland down past the groves of trees and the rain forest and past the bamboo. And as we came to the saddle of the mountain, coming down a different path than we had taken up yesterday, the ranger slowed down. He didn't seem tired, and I couldn't imagine he was slowing out of concern for me. He suddenly seemed cautious, even uncomfortable. It was the nearest I could detect to an emotion on his face.

The forest had opened a bit, there were longer views, and a beautiful stream running alongside our path. We were walking slowly now, the ground was level. We crossed the stream on a log. Another minute walking, and the grove of trees near us parted. And then, with no warning, we were standing in front of Fossey's cabin.

It was plain, small, boarded. A Rwandan flag was flying over it. I walked over toward it, and the ranger motioned me away. I walked closer, and this silent kid told me in French, in Swahili, even in broken but understandable English, that it was not allowed. I walked past the cabin, and for the moment before he forced me away, I stood at the graves of Fossey and the other primates.

Fossey, *Fossey,* you cranky difficult strong-arming self-destructive misanthrope, mediocre scientist, deceiver of earnest college students, probable cause of more deaths of the gorillas than if you had never set foot in Rwanda, Fossey, you pain-in-the-ass saint, I do not believe in prayers or souls, but I will pray for your soul, I will remember you for all of my days, in gratitude for that moment by the graves when all I felt was the pure, cleansing sadness of returning home and finding nothing but ghosts.

Part 4

Adulthood

22

The Baboons: Nick

I didn't much like Nick, and neither did the rest of the troop, in that he had one of the most unappealing personalities I'd encountered in a long time. This was around the time that I was starting to pay attention to personality in a formal, scientific sense. For all those years, I had been focusing on the idea that rank helped determine the health of these animals, that lower-ranking males were more at risk for a variety of stress-related diseases. Rank was destiny, case closed. But my more recent studies suggested that there was more to a baboon's life than his rank. Your physiological profile was indeed influenced by rank, but, it turned out, even more important than that was the sort of society in which the rank occurred—for example, the hormonal profile of a high-ranking male in a stable hierarchy was extremely different during the unstable years. And while rank was important to physiology, an even more significant factor seemed to be whether you had the means to cope when times were tough, whether you were socially affiliated. Thus, independent of rank, males who did the most social grooming and sat in contact with other animals most frequently had the lowest stress hormone levels. This was the realm of an Isaac or a Nat. And, perhaps most importantly, personality was turning out to be crucial. For example, how type A were you?—if your worst rival in the troop showed up and took a nap fifty yards away, would you just keep on doing whatever you had been doing, or would you see it as a crazy-making, in-your-face provocation that would leave you in an agitated state? If you were the kind of baboon for whom a rival napping was a personal affront, you averaged twice the resting stress hormone levels of a male who took it all in stride, after controlling for rank.

So I was thinking a lot about personality, and Nick had a pretty sour one. Basically, he was the meanest baboon to show up since Nebuchanezzar, but,

unlike the latter, he was also smart and disciplined and fearless. He was small and slight, which should have made me root for him, but he had a flinty meanness about him that canceled that out. He made you think of taut little guys with tattoos and prominent veins on their arms, the type who in bar fights demolish the big heavy sloppy guys with vulnerable beer guts. He didn't have tattoos, but he had a distinguishing nick on his lopsided face.

Nick joined the troop during the unstable years. He was still an adolescent, and you could almost read the contempt on his face as he watched the foibles of his elders playing Keystone Kops. Just gimme a coupla years, he seemed to be saying. Meanwhile, he dominated his age group. When he began to make his move into the upper echelon, he was confident and unflinching and played dirty. In a fight one day, he trounced the easily intimidated Reuben, who, in a gesture of submission, stuck his ass up in the air. Now, every baboon on earth knows what that means. It means you give up, you're conceding, uncle, *no mas.* And every baboon on earth knows that at that point, the winner is supposed to merely examine your bottom or mount you, or something conventionally demeaning like that, and it's all over with. Those are the rules, posted everywhere, just like three outs to a side. So Reuben sticks his ass up in the air, Nick comes over as if to examine his bottom, everything going fine, and at the last second, Nick leans over and gives him a deep slash in the ass with his canines. Those happy-go-lucky unstable years were over with a vengeance.

The guy simply wasn't nice. None of the females seemed especially crazy about him, particularly when circumstances put them in a consortship with him for a few days. He harassed the females, swatted at kids, bullied ancient Gums and Limp. On one memorable day, he took exception to something that poor nervous Ruth had done and chased her up a tree. Typically, at this point, the female takes advantage of one of those rare instances when it pays to be smaller than the males—she goes to the farthest end of a flimsy branch and hangs on for dear life, depending on the fact that the heavier male can't crawl out to where she is and bite her. And, typically, the male, thwarted, positions himself to at least trap the female, keeping her screaming on the precarious branch until he gets bored. So Ruth gallops up the tree, Nick after her, and Ruth leaps out to a safe edge. Nick promptly climbs onto a stronger, thicker branch directly above her. And then urinates on her head.

To make matters worse, Nebuchanezzar was in his prime now and had not mellowed over the years. He wasn't challenging Nick for the alpha position but was merely up to making lots of other baboons miserable. There were few saviors in sight. Reuben might have been a match for Nick, but he kept chickening out in every critical fight and even slunk past Nebuchanezzar.

Shem, a muscular new transfer kid, was still a few years away from the big time, as were the other new transfers, Jesse and Samuel. Adam was pathetic and hadn't a hope in the dominance game. David, Daniel, and Jonathan could each fight Nebuchanezzar to a draw but didn't have a chance against Nick. Isaac and Nat were disinterested, Benjamin and Joshua were no match, Saul was a crippled spectator from afar.

About the only hope for the troop was Gideon, but it was going to require some pretty clichéd script writing for him to save the day. Gideon was Nat's kid brother and had recently joined the troop. I had spotted him years before in the neighboring troop—a strikingly muscled kid hanging out with his big brother, the then adolescent Nat. Nat had done his migration years before, had had his brief disinterested reign over the troop before retiring to star in *Father Knows Best.* Then, just as Nick and the Reign of Terror was settling in, Gideon transferred. The scenario was set: Gideon, the young Jedi knight; Nat reluctantly comes out of retirement to be Obi-Wan Kenobi; they form a coalition, overthrow Nick, truth and justice triumph, Han Solo and Princess Leia have a consortship as the movie ends.

The only problem was that Nat was having none of that. Gideon had read the script perfectly, would challenge Nick, and, in the heat of the strategic moment, would barrel over to Nat and solicit a coalition. And Nat, distractedly, would groom Gideon, paying no attention to the hubbub and assuming his kid brother was there merely to reminisce about family picnics. Another day, Gideon would be midbattle with Nebuchanezzar, the outcome seesawing, our hero needing only a hand from his elder brother at a critical moment. Gideon would sprint over, try for a coalition, and Nat would earnestly hand him one of the infants clamoring all over him, hoping Gideon would just settle down and discover how much more rewarding fatherhood was than this fighting nonsense. More than anything, Gideon seemed disillusioned. What had happened to his idolized big brother? Nat, who had taught him everything he knew, goes off to a new troop for a few years and now just look at him—not eating red meat, attending antiwar rallies, hanging out with these girls with no bras. His bewilderment was palpable.

So Gideon seemed unlikely to take over the dominance hierarchy just yet, although he still seemed a shoo-in for Rookie of the Year. A far less auspicious debut in the troop was made by Absolom. He was a meek, squirrely kid who seemed way too young to have already made his adolescent transfer. I didn't recognize him from any of the neighboring troops, suggesting that he had wandered in from a long way off and had spent quite a long time by himself before gaining the most peripheral of footholds in this troop. His open, guileless face

was marred by a large abscess next to his muzzle, which must have been painful, as he chewed only on the opposite side of his mouth. Absolom was atypically friendly, spending an inordinate amount of time eyebrow-flashing and face-pulling at all and sundry. With the exception of Benjamin and of Rachel's family, his greetings were generally ignored. Once, in a particularly adventurous moment, he face-pulled at me; I returned the gesture, clearly a surprise to him that I was conversant in baboon. He face-pulled again, I reciprocated, and we established an almost daily interspecies ritual.

As of late, Absolom had discovered girl baboons and festered in an adolescent voyeurism. The troop had grown accustomed to a certain degree of this obsessiveness in recent years. Jonathan still had a bad crush on Rebecca (who showed increasing foolishness in disdaining him, as he was growing into an impressive young baboon), Adam was still a follower of Short Tail, such that when either of those females was in consortship with some other male, Jonathan or Adam would shadow them at a discreet, forlorn distance. But Absolom took this to new heights. *Any* consortship in the troop, and he would be lurking around in the bushes nearby, trying to catch sight of the good stuff. Daniel would be in consortship with Miriam, who had never really made any of the males' blood run hot, and Absolom would be ten feet away, craning for a view of the action, holding his tail throughout. And let someone who was really hot stuff in the troop come into estrus—Devorah or Boopsie, for example—and Absolom was beside himself. One afternoon, Nick and Devorah, who was sporting a huge estrus swelling, sat quietly grooming each other. They were peripheral to the rest of the troop, secluded, no doubt building steam for a moment of even greater intimacy, when Absolom, who had silently slithered his way out to a branch of the tree just above them for a *really* good view, collapsed it under his weight and came crashing down on top of them. Naturally, despite his obsession, Absolom had not so much as been groomed by a female since joining the troop, let alone anything more exciting, and when I darted him, he was covered with skin parasites.

While Absolom may have been wishing away a few of his years so that he would be closer to his intimidating prime-aged years, some of the other animals must have been feeling the shadows lengthening. Saul was now an old baboon and had taken to limping the quarter mile over to the tourist lodge to contest the local baboons there for garbage scraps in the cans and lodge dump—an easier diet than foraging for hours a day. Aaron, even older and worse off, had retired to that garbage dump troop entirely. Inconceivably, the salacious and youthful Afghan was beginning to look tattered and worn by life, as were Miriam, who seemed to be aging fast from too many kids simul-

taneously throwing tantrums, and Ruth, no doubt done in by her constant skittish anxiety, which had only worsened with the years. Old Naomi was older than ever, and even middle-aged Rachel was beginning to look as tattered as her mother, sufficiently so that more than once I made the mistake of referring to her as Naomi in my field notes. And it was the season that I was shocked to discover that Isaac, and even Joshua and Benjamin, were beginning to get old man's veins—their skin was getting loose and brittle, their veins rolly and difficult to hit with a needle when I was taking blood. And they were beginning to get age spots, of all the disturbing things.

Some of the most remarkable behavior of that period was centered around aging as well. One actor was Gums, who, in his few years in the troop, had generated no anecdotes, seemed to have no notable traits beyond his vast decrepitude. The other was ancient Leah, mother of Devorah, number one–ranking female in the troop, no-nonsense, unlovable. Prior to that season, I am fairly sure I had never seen Leah and Gums so much as look at each other once. Nevertheless, I believe those two fell in love, or fell into each other's hairy arms, or at least fell into a set of behaviors unlike anything I have seen before or since. First, they simply disappeared. The troop slept in the forest, a grove of trees covering a few acres, and it was easy enough for me to lose track of a few animals in the underbrush there, or when the troop would be out foraging on the edge of a thicket. But when the troop was marching across an open field, during the dry season when there was nothing growing but stubble, you couldn't miss a soul. And Leah and Gums just up and evaporated one day. For an adolescent or prime-aged male, this would not be surprising—he was transferring, or at least checking out the possibilities of some other troop. Let one elderly animal disappear, and the hyenas or a lion would be the inevitable suspect. But the two oldest animals in the same day?

There was no sign of them in the neighboring troops, nor of them rummaging through the garbage cans of the tourist lodge. Neither was back in the forest, too sick to come out and forage. I checked the hyena dens for bones, dodged buffalo in the streambed of the forest searching for a fresh skull. Nothing. No one seemed to miss Gums (the fate for most males), but Devorah seemed distracted with the absence of her mother. Days went by, then a week, and I had given up on them, assuming that both had been predated on the same day.

Then, a few days later, I left the baboons midday and drove back to camp via a circuitous track through the backcountry behind the thickets that the baboons frequented. And at the far end, in a field the baboons would go to once in five years, I found the two of them. Together, neither foraging nor

grooming, but sitting near each other. As I approached them, Leah, an animal habituated to humans observing at close range for nearly two decades, glanced up wild-eyed and stiffly loped off to the nearby thicket, followed by the equally wild-eyed Gums.

The next afternoon, as the troop took a route in the opposite direction, placing them ten miles away, I returned to the same remote corner, tracked them even farther up the back end of the thicket. And I spotted them in silhouette at a distance, sitting exposed on a windswept ridge in an area teeming with wildflowers and lions. I never saw them again.

Another event during that period would have been extraordinary with anyone as the protagonist, but was made even more so since it involved an astonishing display of heroism on the part of the unlikely Benjamin. It was midafternoon and the baboons were lollygagging along. Hot as hell, the time of day when predators were most likely sleeping, and everyone's guard was down. The troop came over the top of a streambed and barreled right into a semi-dozing lion. Chaos, screaming, everyone scattering every which way, as the lion leapt up. The big males, naturally, did their thing, which was to high-tail it up the safest trees around. The females, in contrast, sprinted to grab their offspring before heading for the trees. The lion was acting somewhat like a kid in a candy store, starting to sprint after one animal, changing her mind and starting in another direction, overwhelmed by choices. The net result was that she managed to grab no one and stood in the middle of the field, exhaling in exasperation, surrounded by a troop of screaming, treed baboons.

Then all of us—the lion, the baboons, and I—noticed the two kids. They were yearlings, off on the edge, who had climbed up a tiny sapling of a tree, one that bent nearly horizontal within about five feet of the ground, one that would deter a lion for about ten seconds. They were Afghan's and Miriam's, and both moms had been cut off at the opposite end, the lion between them and their kids. General panic and hysteria, as the lion began toward the sapling. Now, the outdated primatology textbooks would go on about how the alpha male would now come to the rescue, as per his job description. And, as I've noted, what actually happens is that a genetic self-interest holds sway—someone will usually do something self-sacrificial only if it involves saving close kin, saving someone who shares lots of genes with them. Tough luck for these two, neither had a really obvious father who had been claiming them—in contrast to the paternalism of, say, Joshua, for Obadiah, Ruth's child from their adolescent dalliance. Most of the big males wa-hooed their heads off at the excitement of having a good view of what was going to happen next, the females were alarm calling, Afghan and Miriam were running up and down the trees frantically,

when, from out of nowhere, Benjamin comes tear-assing in. If during his brief reign as the alpha male he had shown how little he understood modern evolutionary thinking by trying to kidnap the adult Devorah against the menacing Menasseh, now he was showing a similar lack of scholarship—there was no way in hell either of these kids was his. But he comes roaring in, yelling, threat-grunting, gets to the base of the sapling before the lion, and plants himself there. The lion approaches, Benjamin begins snarling and lunging, canines bared. I'm horrified, stunned, mesmerized—as is everyone else. The lion approaches, Benjamin begins to back up the tree, and you can basically see him will himself forward again. He could jump down and run to safety in a second, but he lunges forward, snarling like a lunatic. And it's working. The lion has stopped, now about five feet away, flinching each time Benjamin lunges. She tenses for a spring, lifts a paw . . . and paws at the ground a second and then walks off. Screw it with this crazy baboon in my face, and she returns to where she'd been napping. The two kids run down the tree to their moms.

I'm not sure what I was expecting next. That Miriam and Afghan would groom Benjamin for the rest of time, or at least organize a parade for him. That all the guys would slap him on the back. Everyone continues alarm calling at the lion for a while and then abruptly returns to feeding, while Benjamin bounces around up in a tree, breaking branches in some form of agitated displacement. The rest of the day passes without incident.

During the reign of Nick, most of the changes of membership in the troop were among the younger animals. Obadiah came of age and pushed off for parts unknown, never to be heard from again. Scratch, named for the deep gouge on his nose, was an awkward loopy subadult who joined the troop and went nowhere in the hierarchy, was even pushed around by the hapless Adam, and therefore contented himself to lethargically dominating Absolom and Limp. Jesse, another adolescent transfer, introduced a new behavior, giving credence to the notion of "cultural differences" among different populations of the same species of primates. He came from a troop two territories to the south, living along the river that formed the Kenyan-Tanzanian border, and had clearly spent a lot of time navigating streamlets. He introduced the habit of walking upright across water. Whether this was his own invention or a habit of everyone in his old troop, whether it served some obscure adaptive purpose like reducing exposure to water-borne parasites, or merely saved a baboon from the discomfort of getting his hands *and* feet wet, I never knew, but soon all the younger baboons were crossing streams bipedal.

It was the season that Rebecca had her first child (alas, almost certainly not

by the heartbroken Jonathan, whom I never saw get close to her throughout that estrus period). Primiparous mothers—those with their first child—are rarely particularly skillful, but Rebecca was plain awful. She forgot the kid when she left a group of other females, slapped him frequently, couldn't seem to learn how to position him to ride on her back, so that he sprawled sideways, clutching the base of her tail. One day, as she leapt from one branch to another in a tree with the kid in that precarious position, he lost his grip and dropped ten feet to the ground. We various primates observing proved our close kinship, proved how we probably utilized the exact same number of synapses in our brains in watching and responding to this event, by doing the exact same thing in unison. Five female baboons in the tree and this one human all gasped as one. And then fell silent, eyes trained on the kid. A moment passed, he righted himself, looked up in the tree at his mother, and then scampered off after some nearby friends. And as a chorus, we all started clucking to each other in relief.

So passed that season, with Rebecca slowly learning how to mother, Absolom lurking in the bushes, Nick harassing everyone. He put me in my place in the dominance hierarchy once, and in a particularly galling fashion. It was early morning in the forest, and I had just pulled off a particularly pleasing darting of Reuben. He had been plodding along in a sleepy, just-woke-up manner, and I timed the darting for the instant when he came through a break in the bushes—the dart caught him squarely in the haunch just as his front half disappeared behind the next bush so that he didn't have a chance of seeing what happened. The plan then was for him to obligingly walk a few feet, sit down comfortably in a secluded spot, and pass out. Instead, Reuben lunged at the nearby Adam, zigzagged across the forest, and crossed the deep stream that cut through it, right past an unsavory-looking buffalo. Pain in the neck. I watched until I was certain he was beginning to go under to the anesthetic and unlikely to wander off further, and then began the five-minute drive around to his side of the stream, since the buffalo kept me from crossing on foot.

As I rounded a bend, with his now-prostrate body in view, I suddenly spotted a large male baboon moving toward him quickly. I tensed; it was Nick. It is essential to keep very close watch on a baboon when he is going down, not only because he is likely to wander off and get lost in the bushes when the anesthetic hits, or because he might hurt himself going under to the anesthesia, but for fear that a rival male might maul him during these vulnerable minutes. And now here was Nick barreling down on the semiconscious Reuben and there was no way for me to get to the latter and protect him in time.

I scrambled to get another dart ready to try to hit Nick, but I was too far

away. I thought of leaping out of the car yelling and waving my hands. I hit the horn repeatedly, but Nick still kept coming. Reuben managed to lift his head and focus on Nick, now just a few feet away, and gave a barely conscious fear grimace.

Slowly, forcefully, Nick placed a hand on Reuben's shoulder, the other on his haunch. Then, Nick leaned back and bellowed a wa-hoo call audible throughout the forest, one that would draw the attention of all the baboons still up in the trees. After holding his pose, Nick marched back into the underbrush.

I couldn't believe it. That bastard had just taken credit for my darting.